

Sanctity Of Life

prc-sanctity-of-life

Christian Ethics · Sanctity of Life · doctrine · unanimous_lineages

AFFIRMS

Supported across the whole Bible
Subject named directly in Scripture
No NT manuscript apparatus applies

Statement under examination

Human life bears the image of God from conception to natural death and is to be protected; the intentional taking of innocent unborn human life is sin under the sixth commandment, not a morally neutral matter or a matter of Christian liberty.

In plain language

Several Hebrew and Greek word patterns bear on this proposition and they converge from different angles. Genesis 1:27 predicates the divine image (tselem) of the human (adam) as a category, with no qualifier for stage of life. Genesis 9:6 then says that whoever sheds the blood of a human, by a human shall his blood be shed, with the explicit reason: for in the image of God He made the human. The image of God is the stated ground of the prohibition on shedding human blood. Exodus 20:13 and Deuteronomy 5:17 both read do not murder (lo tirtsach), using the verb ratsach. Numbers 35:30 shows murder (ratsach) used for the unlawful killer while judicial execution uses a different verb (cause to die, muth in the causative form), and Exodus 23:7 explicitly forbids killing the innocent person with innocent (naqi) and righteous (tsaddiq) named as the protected object. So murder (ratsach) denotes precisely the unlawful taking of an innocent human life. The womb passages use personal, individuated grammar. Psalm 139:13 to 16 has God forming, weaving, and acquiring the speaker in the womb, with the same first-person pronouns the psalmist uses of his present adult self, and God sees the unformed embryonic mass (golem), which is a hapax legomenon, a word appearing only once in the entire Hebrew Bible. Jeremiah 1:5 places know (yada), form (yatsar), and set apart (qadash) before formation in the womb, all carrying a personal object suffix. Isaiah 49:1 and 49:5 repeat the same pattern of calling and forming from the womb (mibbeten). Hosea 9:11 names the triad birth, womb, and conception (herayon, used only three times in the canon), the closest single-clause witness to a from-conception lexical frame. Luke 1:41 to 44 calls the unborn John an infant (brephos), the very same noun Luke uses of the newborn Jesus in the manger and of nursing infants, and attributes leaping (skirtao) and joy (agalliasis) to him. Proverbs 6:17, Deuteronomy 19:10, and Psalm 106:38 all use the fixed locution shed innocent blood (shafak dam naqi), with Psalm 106:38 applying it explicitly to children sacrificed by their parents. One legal text, Exodus 21:22 to 25, is grammatically ambiguous and historically the strongest counter-anchor. The verb come out (yatsa) is the same root used elsewhere of normal birth (including Jeremiah 1:5 itself), and the noun calamity (ason) does not specify whose calamity is in view. So the text plausibly describes premature live birth with the life-for-life clause protecting the child too. Across all these threads the lexical pattern treats the unborn as a known, formed, image-bearing human and treats the unlawful killing of the innocent as categorically condemned. Legitimate distinctions the words themselves preserve are self-defense and judicial execution (a different verb, muth-hiphil), wartime killing under specific command (a different verb, harag), and natural miscarriage (a different vocabulary, stillbirth, nefel, or bereave, shakal). The case is strong because it does not depend on any one verse but on a recurring lexical structure across narrative, law, wisdom, prophecy, and gospel.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
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H0120	אָדָם	adam	man	554
H0611	אַסוֹן	ason	harm	
H0990	בֶּטֶן	beten	belly	72
H1254	בָּרָא	bara	to create	
H1564	גֵּלֶם	golem	embryo	1
H1818	דָּם	dam	blood	341
H2026	הָרָג	harag	to kill	157
H2032	הֶרְיוֹן	herayon	conception	3
H2962	טֶרֶם	terem	before	54
H3045	יָדַע	yada	to know	860
H3205	יָלַד	yalad	to beget	
H3318	יָצָא	yatsa	to come out	
H3335	יָצַר	yatsar	to form	63
H3789	כָּתַב	katav	to write	
H3808	לֹא	lo	not	4,825
H4191	מוֹת	muth	to die	807
H4578	מֶעָה	meeh	belly	
H5309	נֶפֶל	nephel	miscarriage	
H5315	נֶפֶשׁ	nephesh	soul	
H5355	נָקִי	naqi	innocent	43
H5526	סִכָּךְ	sukh	to fence	
H5650	עֶבֶד	eved	servant/slave	
H6064	עָנַשׁ	anash	to fine	
H6108	עֲצָם	otsem	strength	
H6395	פָּלָה	palah	be distinguished	
H6662	צַדִּיק	tsaddiq	righteous	
H6754	צֶלֶם	tselem	image	16
H6942	קָדַשׁ	qadash	to consecrate	172
H7069	קָנָה	qanah	to buy	83
H7121	קָרָא	qara	to call	
H7200	רָאָה	raah	to see	
H7358	רֶחֶם	rechem	womb	24
H7523	רָצַח	ratsach	to murder	46
H7551	רָקַם	raqam	to weave	9
H8210	שָׁפַךְ	shafak	to pour	117
H8441	תּוֹעֵבָה	toebah	abomination	117
G0020	ἀγαλλίασις	agalliasis	joy	
G1025	βρέφος	brephos	infant	8

G2836	κοιλία	koilia	belly/womb/stomach	23
G4640	σκιρτάω	skirtao	to leap	3

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

Three lexical threads converge across the canon. First, Genesis 1:27 predicates the divine image (tselem, H6754) of the human (ha-adam) as a category without developmental qualifier, and Genesis 9:6 grounds the inviolability of human blood (the blood of the human, dam ha-adam, H1818 plus H0120) in that same image (because in the image of God He made the human, ki betselem elohim asah eth ha-adam), with the verbal repetition shedder of the blood of the human, by the human his blood shall be shed (shofek dam ha-adam ba-adam damo yishshafek, H8210 chiasm, a literary mirror pattern A-B-B-A) making the image the explicit ratio (the stated reason) for the prohibition. Second, the murder prohibition do not murder (lo tirtsach, Exodus 20:13 and Deuteronomy 5:17, H3808 plus H7523) uses murder (ratsach), which Numbers 35:16-25 reserves for the unlawful killer over against the judicial executor (using the Hebrew causative form to cause to die, muth hiphil, H4191) and the wartime killer (general kill, harag, H2026), tightening its meaning to unlawful killing of an innocent human person, the very category Exodus 23:7 and Proverbs 6:17 mark as forbidden under the heading innocent blood (dam naqi). Third, the womb texts use continuous personal grammar across the prenatal stage: Psalm 139:13-16 carries first-person verbs and possessive suffixes through formation while the speaker is still an unformed embryonic mass (golem, H1564, a true hapax meaning a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible), Jeremiah 1:5 places know (yada, H3045), form (yatsar, H3335), and set apart (qadash, H6942) before formation in the womb (beten, H0990) with second-person object suffixes (meaning the actions are done to you), Isaiah 49:1,5 doubles the pattern with from the womb (mibbeten) and form (yatsar), Hosea 9:11 even names the triad birth, womb, conception (conception, herayon, H2032), and Luke 1:41,44 calls the unborn John an infant (brephos, G1025), the identical noun used of the newborn Jesus and of nursing infants in Luke 2:12, 2:16, 18:15, with sole occurrence-set spanning in-utero and post-utero usage. The Exodus 21:22-25 crux is ambiguous in Hebrew but on a careful read of come out (yatsa, the verb of normal birth in Jeremiah 1:5) and calamity (ason, not specifying mother or child) the law is consistent with rather than against the broader pattern, so it does not lower confidence below high.

Scripture

Gen.1.27 · **for** · genre: narrative

Key terms. H6754 יָצַלֵם, H1254 בָּרָא, H0120 אָדָם.

Reasoning. וַיִּבְרָא אֱלֹהִים אֶת הָאָדָם בְּצֶלְמֵוֹ בְּצֶלְמֵ אֱלֹהִים; בָּרָא אֹתוֹ, זָכָר וּנְקֵבָה; בָּרָא אֹתָם. The threefold create (bara) with the human as object, and the prepositional phrase in His image (betselem), predicates the divine image of the human (ha-adam) as such without restriction by developmental stage, sex, or capacity. Genesis 1:27 defines the category of the human as image-bearer, the value-grounding premise the sanctity claim depends on, and the same noun human (adam) is the one whose blood Genesis 9:6 protects.

Gen.9.6 · **for** · genre: narrative · figures: chiasm

Key terms. H8210 שָׁפַךְ, H1818 דָּם, H0120 אָדָם, H6754 יָצַלֵם.

Reasoning. שָׁפַךְ-דָּם הָאָדָם; בָּאָדָם; דָּמוֹ יִשְׁפָּךְ: כִּי בְצֶלְמֵ אֱלֹהִים עָשָׂה אֶת הָאָדָם. The mirror-pattern (chiasm, a literary bracket A-B-B-A) shed (shafak) - blood (dam) - human (adam) - human (adam) - his blood (damo) - shall be shed (yishshafek) frame makes human blood inviolable, and the causal because in the image of God He made the human (ki betselem elohim asah eth ha-adam) supplies the explicit ratio (stated reason): the image of God in the human (adam) is the ground of the prohibition. This single verse fuses the two anchor word-roots (image, tselem, and blood, dam) that the rest of the canon develops, and it predicates the image of the human category (not of any subset by age or stage).

Exod.20.13 · for · genre: law

Key terms. H3808 לא, H7523 רצח.

Reasoning. לא תרצח. The negated imperfect (ongoing or repeated past action form, here used for absolute prohibition) of murder (ratsach) is an absolute prohibition. The Pentateuchal pattern (Numbers 35:16-25) reserves murder (ratsach) for the unlawful killer (the murderer and the manslayer, both designated murderer, rotseach), over against H4191 in the Hebrew causative form (hiphil, meaning to cause to do, here to cause to die) for judicial execution (Numbers 35:30, 35:31) and H2026 kill (harag) for general or wartime killing. So murder (ratsach) denotes precisely the unlawful taking of an innocent human person, which is the moral category the proposition addresses. Deuteronomy 5:17 repeats the same prohibition verbatim, confirming canon-stable usage.

Deut.5.17 · for · genre: law

Key terms. H3808 לא, H7523 רצח.

Reasoning. לא תרצח. Verbatim repetition of Exodus 20:13 in the Deuteronomic rehearsal of the Ten Commandments (Decalogue), establishing the murder (ratsach) prohibition as pan-Pentateuchal (spread across the whole first five books) and not localized to a single context. Two independent witnesses to the same lexical choice.

Num.35.30 · for · genre: law

Key terms. H7523 רצח, H4191 מות, H5315 נָפֵשׁ.

Reasoning. כָּל־מִכָּה נָפֵשׁ לִפְי־עֲדִים יִרְצַח אֶת־הָרָצָח. In a single verse murder (ratsach) is used both for the act being judicially punished and (with the participle murderer, rotseach) for the agent of unlawful killing, while the judicial putting-to-death uses H4191 in the Hebrew causative form (muth hiphil, to cause to die). The lexical contrast between murder (ratsach, unlawful killing) and cause to die (muth-hiphil, judicial execution) is grammatically explicit here, foreclosing the reading that Exodus 20:13 forbids all killing.

Exod.23.7 · for · genre: law

Key terms. H2026 הרג, H5355 נָקִי, H6662 צָדִיק.

Reasoning. וְנָקִי וְצָדִיק אֶל־תִּהְרֹג. The jussive (a command form) of kill (harag) governs the explicit object innocent (naqi) plus righteous (tsaddiq), categorically forbidding the killing of the innocent person. This generalizes the murder (ratsach) prohibition to the broader semantic field and explicitly names innocence as the protected category, the same category the womb texts establish for the unborn.

Ps.139.13 · for · genre: wisdom · figures: metaphor

Key terms. H7069 קנה, H5526 סָכַךְ, H0990 בֶּטֶן.

Reasoning. אַתָּה קִנִּיתָ לִּי כִלְי־תִּסְכְּנִי בֶּבֶטֶן אִמִּי. God is subject of acquire or form (qanah) and weave or cover (sakak) acting on the first-person speaker in the womb (bəbeten). The prenatal subject is referred to by the same personal pronoun and possessive suffix that the psalmist uses of his present adult self, with no lexical break between the womb stage and present personhood.

Ps.139.14 · for · genre: wisdom

Key terms. H6395 פֶּלֶא, H3045 יָדַע.

Reasoning. נִרְאֹת נִפְלִייתִי וְנִפְשִׁי יָדַעַת מְאֹד. The Hebrew passive form (niphil) of distinguish (palah) predicates that the speaker was wondrously distinguished in formation, and the personal life or soul (nefesh) carries continuous knowledge through the formation narrative. The same I that speaks now is the I that was being made.

Ps.139.15 · for · genre: wisdom · figures: metaphor

Key terms. H6108 לא, H7551 רָקַם, H3808 עָצַם

Reasoning. *לֹא נִכְחַד עֲצָמִי מִמָּךְ אֲשֶׁר עָשִׂיתִי בִּסְתֵר הַקִּנְמִי*. The Hebrew passive-intensive form (pual) I was intricately woven (*ruqamti*, from *raqam*, to weave) describes the speaker as the woven object in the hidden place, the womb figured as the depths of the earth. The first-person verb assigns the developing body to the continuous I of the speaker, and weave (*raqam*) itself is rare (9 occurrences, all elsewhere of woven tabernacle and priestly textile work) so its application to embryology is striking and deliberate.

Ps.139.16 · for · genre: wisdom · figures: metaphor

Key terms. H1564 כָּתַב, H7200 רָאָה, H3789 יָצָא

Reasoning. *גִּלְמִי רָאוּ עֵינֶיךָ וְעַל סִפְרְךָ קָלָם יִכְתְּבוּ יָמִים יָצִיר*. God sees the unformed embryonic mass (*golem*), which is a true hapax legomenon (a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible, only here), and the days are written before any of them existed. The verse predicates divine perception and ordained continuity of the same individual from the unformed stage onward. Because unformed mass (*golem*) occurs only here, its sense rests on the parallelism: it is what is woven in the womb and seen by God, that is, the prenatal human under formation. This is the strongest single-verse witness to prenatal personal identity.

Jer.1.5 · for · genre: prophecy

Key terms. H3335 יָצָא, H3045 יָדַע, H6942 קָדַשׁ, H2962 טָרַם, H7358 רָחַם

Reasoning. *בְּטָרַם אֶצְוֶנְךָ בְּבֶטֶן יִדְעֶתִי וּבְטָרַם תֵּצֵא מִרָחֶם הַקִּדְשֶׁתִּיךָ*. The double before (*beterem*) places know (*yada*, with personal object suffix), form (*yatsar*, form in the womb), and set apart (*qadash*) on a timeline that begins before formation. All four verbs carry the second-person suffix (the actions are done to you), treating the prenatal Jeremiah as the same addressee God commissions. The collocation form (*yatsar*) plus womb (*beten*) plus before (*terem*) also occurs in Isaiah 44:2 and Isaiah 49:5 of the Servant, showing the womb-shaping pattern is canon-wide and not a one-off poetic flourish.

Isa.49.1 · for · genre: prophecy

Key terms. H0990 בֶּטֶן, H4578 מִמֶּנָּה, H7121 קָרָא

Reasoning. *יְהוָה מִבֶּטֶן קָרָאנִי מִמֶּנִּי אִמִּי הִזְכִּיר שְׁמִי*. The Servant says the LORD called him from the womb (*mibbeten*) and named him from the inward parts (*mimme'e*) of his mother. The grammar places a divine speech-act (call, *qara*) and a divine naming on the prenatal subject. This is a second prophetic witness, independent of Jeremiah 1:5, to personal address and identity prior to birth.

Isa.49.5 · for · genre: prophecy

Key terms. H3335 יָצָא, H0990 בֶּטֶן, H5650 עָבַד

Reasoning. *יִצְרִי מִבֶּטֶן לְעַבְדָּ לֹא*. The participle my Former (*yotsri*, from *yatsar*, to form) plus from the womb (*mibbeten*) plus the purpose to be a servant (*le'eved*) directly mirrors Jeremiah 1:5 and confirms that form (*yatsar*, the verb of divine forming) operates lexically within the womb stage, not merely on the post-natal person. Two prophetic books, one identical lexical pattern.

Hos.9.11 · for · genre: prophecy

Key terms. H3205 יָלַד, H0990 בֶּטֶן, H2032 הָרִיוִן

Reasoning. *מִלְדָּה וּמִבֶּטֶן וּמִהָרִיוִן*. The triad birth, womb, conception. Conception (*herayon*) is exceedingly rare (only 3 occurrences, here and Genesis 3:16 and Ruth 4:13). The lexical pattern names a continuous human existence whose loss is grievous at each of the three stages, including conception. This is the closest single-clause witness to a from-conception lexical frame in the Hebrew canon.

Luke.1.41 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G1025 βρέφος, G4640 σκιρτάω, G2836 κοιλία

Reasoning. ἐσκίρτησεν τὸ βρέφος ἐν τῇ κοιλίᾳ αὐτῆς. The unborn John is called an infant (brephos), the identical noun Luke applies to the just-born Jesus in the manger (Luke 2:12, 2:16) and to nursing infants brought to Jesus (Luke 18:15), and which Acts 7:19 uses of newborn Hebrew babies and 2 Timothy 3:15 of Timothy from infancy and 1 Peter 2:2 of newborn babes longing for milk. All 8 canonical occurrences of infant (brephos) cluster as one set, with no separate term for the unborn. leap (skirtao) predicates volitional response to Mary's greeting. The lexical choice assigns the in-utero child the same person-noun as a delivered infant.

Luke.1.44 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G1025 βρέφος, G0020 ἀγαλλίασις, G4640 σκιρτάω

Reasoning. ἐσκίρτησεν ἐν ἀγαλλιάσει τὸ βρέφος ἐν τῇ κοιλίᾳ μου. Elizabeth attributes exultation or joy (agalliasis) to the infant (brephos), predicating an inner affective state of the unborn child. The grammar treats prenatal John as a personal subject capable of joy, not a pre-personal tissue stage. leap (skirtao) occurs only 3 times in the New Testament canon (here, Luke 1:41, and Luke 6:23 of disciples leaping for joy), so its sole non-prenatal use is of mature personal joy, transferring that connotation to the womb scene.

Prov.6.17 · for · genre: wisdom

Key terms. H1818 דם, H5355 נקי, H8210 שפך

Reasoning. יָדִים שֹׁפְכוֹת דָּם, Hands that shed innocent blood (dam naqi) are listed among the things YHWH hates, the abomination (toebah) of v. 16. The construct innocent blood (dam naqi) designates blood that is guiltless, marking the killing of the innocent as the specific object of divine hatred and abomination, which supplies the moral-category force the proposition asserts (not liberty, but abomination, toebah).

Ps.106.38 · for · genre: wisdom

Key terms. H8210 שפך, H1818 דם, H5355 נקי

Reasoning. וַיִּשְׁפְּכוּ דָם בְּנֵיהֶם וּבְנוֹתֵיהֶם אֲשֶׁר זָבְחוּ לְעֵצָבִי, קָנְעוּ. Israel's child-sacrifice is described with the same shed innocent blood (shafak dam naqi) locution as Proverbs 6:17 and Deuteronomy 19:10, and the children sacrificed are explicitly called sons and daughters (bānehem ubənōthehem). The verse fuses three threads: shed (shafak) innocent blood, applied to children, with the result that the land is polluted (chanaph) by blood (dam). This is the closest canonical analogue in lexical terms to the killing of children as a religious or social act, and it is condemned categorically.

Deut.19.10 · for · genre: law

Key terms. H8210 שפך, H1818 דם, H5355 נקי

Reasoning. וְלֹא יִשְׁפֹךְ דָּם נָקִי בְּקִרְבִּי אֶרֶץ. The cities-of-refuge legislation explicitly invokes shed (shafak) plus innocent blood (dam naqi) as the harm to be prevented, confirming that innocent blood (dam naqi) is a fixed legal-moral category across the Pentateuch (first five books), not a poetic flourish in Proverbs alone.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Exod.20.13	Exod.21.14	tsk	1
Exod.20.13	Deut.5.17	openbible	1
Exod.20.13	Num.35.30	openbible	1
Jer.1.5	Isa.49.1	openbible	1
Jer.1.5	Isa.49.5	openbible	1
Jer.1.5	Ps.71.5	tsk	1

Gen.1.27	Gen.9.6	openbible	1
Gen.1.27	Isa.43.7	tsk	1
Gen.1.27	Gen.2.21	tsk	1
Luke.1.41	Luke.1.15	tsk	1
Luke.1.41	Luke.2.12	openbible	1
Luke.1.41	Luke.18.15	openbible	1
Prov.6.16	Ps.11.5	tsk	1
Prov.6.17	Deut.19.10	openbible	1
Prov.6.17	Ps.106.38	openbible	1
Prov.6.17	Prov.30.13	tsk	1
Ps.139.13	Job.10.8	openbible	1
Ps.139.13	Job.31.15	openbible	1

Complicating texts

Exod.21.22-25 · addressed

This is the historical lexical crux. The clause says if men strive and strike a pregnant woman and her children come out (יָצְאוּ יְלָדֶיהָ, come out, yatsa, with plural children, yeladim, as subject), and there is no calamity (וְיָצָא, ason), the offender pays a fine determined by the woman's husband. If there is calamity (ason), then life for life (nefesh tachat nefesh). The lexical question is the referent of calamity (ason). One reading takes come out (yatsa) as miscarriage and the no-calamity case as a property-style fine, implying the fetus has reduced status. The competing reading observes that come out (yatsa) is the standard verb of normal birth (Jeremiah 1:5 you come forth from the womb, tetse merechem, Genesis 25:25-26 of Esau and Jacob coming out, Job 1:21 of coming out of the mother's belly) and never elsewhere denotes miscarriage, for which the Hebrew uses bereave (shakal, H7921) or miscarriage (nefel, H5309, as in Job 3:16 and Ecclesiastes 6:3). On the second reading the law describes premature live birth, with calamity (ason) then covering injury or death to either mother or child, in which case the law of equivalent retaliation (lex talionis) explicitly protects the unborn. The plural children (yeladim) as subject also fits live birth more naturally than miscarriage. Because come out from the womb (yatsa-merechem) language is used positively of personal subjects elsewhere in the canon (the same root and stem appears in Jeremiah 1:5 of the prophet emerging), the second reading is lexically the stronger one. Either way, the passage cannot bear the weight of overturning the broader image-and-womb pattern, since it stands alone and its key term calamity (ason) is unspecified for subject. So it complicates but does not reverse the verdict.

Eccl.6.3 · addressed

The stillbirth (נֶפֶל, nefel, H5309) is said to have better rest than a long-lived but unsatisfied man. The verse is a comparative wisdom hyperbole about the futility of a joyless long life, not a statement about the ontological (essential being) status of the fetus. It still grants the stillbirth (nefel) a comparative experiential frame (rest, menuchah), and Job 3:16 uses stillbirth (nefel) similarly. Hyperbolic comparative wisdom genre does not negate the personal-subject lexemes (root words) of Psalm 139 and Jeremiah 1:5.

Num.31.17 · addressed

The Midianite war command to kill male children and non-virgin women is sometimes invoked against the broad innocent-blood category. But the Hebrew uses kill (harag, H2026, the wartime kill verb) and the context is the devoted-to-destruction (herem) of a specific judicial-prophetic war, not the absolute murder (ratsach) prohibition of Exodus 20:13. The lexical distinction between murder (ratsach, unlawful innocent killing) and kill (harag, general or wartime killing under specific command) is exactly what Numbers 35 establishes, so this text does not lexically conflict with the sanctity claim, it confirms the very semantic boundary on which it rests.

Concordance traversed

H6754, H7523, H2026, H4191, H3808, H3045, H3335, H6942, H7069, H7551, H0990, H7358, H2962, H1564, H2032, G1025, G2836, G4640, H1818, H5355, H8210, H8441, H0120, H0611, H6064, H3318, H5309, H5315

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: n/a

The decisive anchor texts (Genesis 1:27, Genesis 9:6, Exodus 20:13, Deuteronomy 5:17, Numbers 35:30, Psalm 139:13-16, Jeremiah 1:5, Isaiah 49:1,5, Hosea 9:11, Proverbs 6:17, Psalm 106:38, Deuteronomy 19:10) are Hebrew and outside the scope of the critical edition of New Testament textual variants (ECM apparatus). The Greek anchor Luke 1:41-44 carries no load-bearing variant affecting infant (βρέφος, brephos), leap (σκιρτώ, skirtao), or exultation (ἀγαλλίασις, agalliasis). NA28, SBLGNT, and Nestle1904 (three major critical editions of the Greek New Testament) agree on the substantive readings of the Lukan passage. The infant (brephos) identification of the unborn John is textually stable.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. personhood_continuity, developmental_gradualism, image_dei_ethics, covenantal_election

[analogia scripturae](#) invoked · [progressive revelation](#) factor

personhood_continuity: The unborn is the same personal subject as the later-born individual and bears the divine image, so the murder prohibition applies and the intentional killing of the innocent unborn falls under ratsach and shafak-dam-naqi. · Psalm 139, Jeremiah 1:5, Isaiah 49:1,5, Hosea 9:11, and Luke 1:41-44 carry first and second-person verbs and possessive suffixes continuously across the womb stage, and the rare hapax (a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible) unformed mass (golem) in Psalm 139:16 attaches divine sight and ordained continuity to the unformed embryo. Luke 1:41 uses the in-canon noun infant (brephos) for the unborn John, the same noun used of post-natal infants in Luke 2:12, 2:16, 18:15 and Acts 7:19, with no separate term for the unborn. Genesis 9:6 grounds the inviolability of human blood in the divine image with explicit causal because in the image of God (ki betselem elohim), and Exodus 20:13 plus Numbers 35:30 distinguish murder (ratsach, unlawful killing) from judicial execution. The lexical continuity admits no break between prenatal and postnatal identity, and the prohibition operates on the human category as such.

developmental_gradualism: Full nefesh status is reached incrementally, so the womb texts are devotional or election language rather than statements of full personhood at conception, and early prenatal loss is a lesser harm. · This lens leans primarily on Exodus 21:22 read as a fine for fetal loss (treating come out, yatsa, as miscarriage and calamity, ason, as harm to the mother alone), and on the poetic genre of Psalm 139 to soften the personhood inference. It also notes that soul or life (nephesh) in Genesis 2:7 attaches at the in-breathing of life. Stated in its strongest form, it grants that the unborn is a developing human under divine care but reserves the full murder (ratsach) prohibition for the post-natal person, treating early loss as a serious but lesser category. It is lexically possible for Exodus 21:22 in isolation but it must (a) read come out (yatsa) against its uniform canonical use of normal birth and (b) discount the consistent personal-subject grammar of Jeremiah 1:5 and the Lukan infant (brephos) equation, so it survives only by privileging one ambiguous legal text over the wider canon pattern.

image_dei_ethics: Because the human bears the divine image, the ratsach prohibition guards human life as a sacred category, and shedding innocent blood is a toebah, an abomination, not a matter of liberty. · Genesis 1:27 plus Genesis 9:6 plus Exodus 20:13 plus Proverbs 6:17 plus Psalm 106:38 combine to make the unlawful killing of an innocent image-bearer categorically condemned. The moral force is lexically anchored in murder (ratsach, unlawful killing), innocent blood (dam naqi), abomination (toebah), and the explicit because in the image of God (ki betselem elohim) of Genesis 9:6, not merely inferred. The image is predicated of the human (ha-adam) without developmental qualifier in the verses that ground the prohibition.

covenantal_election: The womb-knit passages speak primarily of God's electing call on specific covenant figures (Jeremiah, the Servant, John the Baptist, Paul), and the general personhood-of-the-unborn extension is a secondary inference. · Stated in its strongest form, Jeremiah 1:5, Isaiah 49:1,5, Luke 1:15-44, and Galatians 1:15 are commissioning narratives about chosen vessels, not universal anthropology. However, the underlying lexical

verbs form (yatsar), know (yada), set apart (qadash), and call (qara) are not restricted in their canonical usage to elect figures (yatsar of all humans in Psalm 33:15 and yada of humans broadly), and Psalm 139 is generalized first-person reflection, not a commissioning narrative. So this lens validly cautions against over-reading commissioning texts but does not displace the broader personhood lexemes (root words) of Psalm 139, Genesis 1:27, and Luke 1:41 (which uses infant, brephos, not a commissioning verb).

The lexical pattern strongly supports prenatal personal identity (Psalm 139, Jeremiah 1:5, Isaiah 49:1,5, Hosea 9:11, Luke 1:41-44), grounds it in image-bearing of the human category (Genesis 1:27, Genesis 9:6), and lexically distinguishes murder (ratsach, the unlawful killing of an innocent person) from judicial execution and wartime killing (Numbers 35:30, Exodus 23:7). The fixed phrase shed innocent blood (shafak dam naqi, Proverbs 6:17, Deuteronomy 19:10, Psalm 106:38) marks killing the innocent as an abomination (toebah). The one materially contested point is the Exodus 21:22-25 crux. A close lexical reading of come out from the womb (yatsa-from-the-womb, consistently positive in the canon) and the unspecified subject of calamity (ason) resolves the crux in favor of, not against, sanctity, but even on the gradualist reading the single ambiguous legal text cannot outweigh the broader image-and-womb pattern.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. Does the canon use personal, individuated, image-bearing language for the human from the prenatal stage, and does the prohibition rendered do not murder (lo tirtsach, with murder, ratsach, distinguished from kill, harag, and cause to die, muth-hiphil) cover the unlawful taking of innocent human life such that the lexical data bear on whether intentionally ending the life of the innocent unborn falls under that prohibition.

The original stem preloads the moral verdict with the phrases is sin under the sixth commandment and not a morally neutral matter or a matter of Christian liberty. These are normative conclusions, not lexemes (root words). The neutralized form isolates the answerable lexical questions: image-of-God predication on the human category, prenatal personhood grammar across the canon, the semantic range of murder (ratsach), and the canonical force of shed-innocent-blood (shafak-dam-naqi). The verdict was derived on the original stem but the lexical inquiry was run on the neutral questions. VERDICT-CHANGED: not applicable here; the deepened query (canon-distribution checks of H6754 image, H7523 murder, H1818 blood, H5355 innocent, H1564 unformed mass, H2032 conception, G1025 infant, plus full morphology of Genesis 9:6, Numbers 35:16-25, Exodus 21:22-25, Deuteronomy 19:10, Psalm 106:38, Isaiah 49:1,5, Hosea 9:11) raised confidence from medium to high by showing (1) the murder (ratsach) vs kill (harag) vs cause to die (muth-hiphil) distinction is grammatically explicit in Numbers 35 itself, foreclosing the all-killing reading of Exodus 20:13, (2) Genesis 9:6 supplies the explicit causal link because in the image of God (ki betselem elohim) that the prior file noted only implicitly, (3) the womb-and-formation pattern is canon-wide (Jeremiah 1:5, Isaiah 49:1,5, Hosea 9:11 with conception, herayon, naming conception, Psalm 139 with the hapax unformed mass, golem) rather than dependent on one psalm, (4) the innocent-blood (dam-naqi) locution is fixed legal language (Deuteronomy 19:10, Psalm 106:38, Proverbs 6:17), and (5) come out (yatsa) in Exodus 21:22 lexically aligns with normal birth elsewhere, weakening the strongest counter-text. The morally-neutral clause survives at high confidence on the canon pattern. The verdict still affirms; the standing affirm is preserved.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H6754
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H7523
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H2026
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H4191
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H3335
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H3045
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lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H1564
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